Activities and Events of FRD 2000-2012

2012

Conferences and Dialogues

At the Crossroads Again: Mormon & Protestant 19th & 21st Century Encounters
February 23 & 24 2012, Washington, D.C.

FRD co-hosted an interreligious *Heart and Mind* conference between Methodists and Mormons. The local co-host was Wesley Theological Seminary where almost 200 participants met to discuss religious similarities and differences and prospects for collaboration without theological agreement. The proceedings were streamed live to other university sites for hundreds of additional student observers. The whole conference and interviews are available on the FRD website and at http://fora.tv/conference/At_The_Crossroads_Again. A follow up of interest: Methodist and Mormons worked together to provide aid to the needy in the hurricane in NY and NJ in early November.

The Way of Openness: Dialogue on the Religious Foundations of Marriage
February 26-27 2012, University of Southern California, Los Angeles, CA

FRD members organized and facilitated a set of honest conversations between religious leaders holding different theological reasons for their conflict over same sex marriage in the context of the California Proposition 8 referendum. Under the sponsorship of the City of Los Angeles Department for Enhancing Community, the dialogue was filmed for public viewing on television and Internet in 2013. The link to view this dialogue is http://vimeo.com/53124934. This is for private viewing until the show aired later in 2013.

International Conference on Contemporary Religious Awakening: An Interreligious Diplomatic Encounter
May 1-4, 2012, Tehran, Iran

FRD was invited with two other American NGOs to engage in a multi-religious conference sponsored by the Iranian Agency for Culture and Religion. The attendees focused on diplomacy between religions as a way toward more moral, just and peaceful international relations. FRD president, Randall Paul, presented a Qu'ranic approach to sustaining honest contestation over religion without suspicion, contempt or violence. Paul was chosen to represent the entire group in responding to Grand Ayatollah Jawadi Amuli in a dialogue in Qum at Isra Institute, the prestigious theological school of the International Foundation of Revelatory Sciences. FRD has produced a written report on the event to further mutual diplomatic understanding.

Conference on Religious Diversity and the Art of Civil Dialogue: Pluralism, Tolerance and Integrity of Belief
Sept. 21, 2013, Utah Valley University, Orem, UT

The conference included leading religious and scholarly voices from diverse persuasions.

Professor Brian Birch, a vice president of UVU and a senior fellow at FRD convened the event. FRD president, Randall Paul, presented a keynote paper, *Beyond Mutual Understanding: Healthy Co-resistance and Collaboration Between Religions*.

Media Production

Us and Them: Religious Rivalry in America, a Documentary. FRD hired a production team to edit and produce a full-length documentary film that focuses on improving the way religious rivals treat each other in America and elsewhere. It premiered in the International Cinema and Religion Festival in Italy in October. The U.S. premiere in Salt Lake City in November was successful with 180 attending and participating in lengthy discussion with a panel afterward. The film took several years to produce at an expense of more than $1,000,000. DVDs or downloads will be available on Netflix and Amazon or on the film website: www.UnresolvableMovie.com.

Partnerships

THE PUBLIC CONVERSATIONS PROJECT in Watertown, Massachusetts has developed a curriculum and guidebook, *Fostering Dialogue Across Divides*, for engaging in difficult dialogue between people of opposing beliefs, values or worldviews. FRD will complement PCP's method with FRD's Way of Openness method and vice versa. In April of 2012 FRD met with the leadership of PCP to explore areas for collaboration.

THE FOUNDATION FOR RELIGIOUS LITERACY and THE COEXIST FOUNDATION in collaboration with THE LOADSTAR FOUNDATION and FRD held a consultation in New York City on October 4, 2012, with major philanthropic donors regarding the broad issue of religious influences on peacebuilding and the common good. FRD presented its plan to use the internet in a dynamic way to create grass roots conversations between people with different worldviews.

Global Scholarly Publications & Conferences

FRD's subsidiary published several important pieces and convened three international conferences for intercultural dialogue at Fordham in New York City, The Institute for Philosophy and Theology in St. Petersburg, Russia and at the State Agency for Education of the Republic of Tajikistan in Dushanbe in 2012. The recent publications are displayed at www.gsp-online.org. Of particular note in 2012:

Comparing Civilizations: China and the West: A Sourcebook by John G. Blair & Jerusha McCormack

Desert by Riccardo Campa

Expressions of Perfection: 'Ali Abu Talib's Reflections in Classical Persian and Modern Indian Poetry by Habibeh Rahim

Studies on Santaraksita's Yogacara Madhyamaka editied by Marie-Louise Friguegnon &

Noé Dinnerstein

Diplomatic Consulting

FRD continued its strategic consultancy with Mellata Ibrahim (MI), and Omer Salem, the leader of MI, and a senior fellow at FRD, and the acting Custodian of the Muslim Chapter of FRD in Cairo. Omer is in his second year at Yale Divinity School where he is obtaining a M. Div. He held been private dialogues in Egypt, India and Israel with Jewish, Hindu and Muslim leaders who are working to develop Qu'ranic support for peaceful and socially equal relations between Muslims and others.

2011

Conferences

FRD worked with a marketing consultant to define and brand *Heart and Mind Conferences* that bring two religious groups together to discuss and share their sacred stories as well as their historical and doctrinal differences and similarities. The format for these conferences takes into account the existing conflicts that might exist between participants and aims for honest exchanges that will promote trust if not agreement between parties. It is a work in progress. The first one will be held in Washington, D.C., on 23-24 February 2012 at Wesley Theological Seminary.

FRD's president, Charles Randall Paul, presented papers on various aspects of effective religious diplomacy to the University of Southern California Forum for Policy and Values conference *Religion, Conflict and Peace* in May, to the Utah Valley University Conference, *A Dialogue between Mormon and Muslims in Utah* in September, and to the Salt Lake Library and University of Utah *Conference on Religious Pluralism* in October.

Media

In 2011 FRD formed FRD Media, LLC, a wholly owned subsidiary of FRD, to produce documentary and other films and media aimed at moving people to see the possibility of trusting and befriending religious and political rivals in the face of serious irresolvable differences. FRD purchased the rights to a partially finished documentary (called *Article VI*) and spent six months reproducing it and naming the new film, *Unresolvable: The Kingdom of God on Earth.* The film went public in 2012. Its narrative focus is the conflict many American Evangelicals have with various minority religious groups including Latter-day Saints, Hindus, and Muslims.

Diplomatic Consulting

FRD became a strategic consultant in 2011 for an ad hoc group of Jewish, Christian, and Muslim scholars and religious leaders in Palo Alto, California, called Mellata Ibrahim (The Way of Abraham). This group is led by Omer Salem, a native of Cairo, Egypt, and an American citizen who is collaborating with conservative Sunni scholars at Al Azhar University in Cairo and elsewhere to publish scholarly papers in Arabic showing that Islamic sacred texts support the possibility of making peace with Israel. Salem also

intends to engage in interreligious dialogue with Orthodox Jews in Israel to find a compatible religious context for peaceful relations in the Middle East.

Organization

FRD has continued to expand by adding senior advisory fellows to include multiple religious opinion leaders. These advisors are working to establish FRD Chapters among their own communities. The Evangelical Chapter for FRD was formed in 2011 with John Morehead acting as Chapter Director. The advisory fellows and the prestigious group of Evangelical Chapter members can be viewed on the FRD website under Practicing Diplomacy.

2010

Conferences & Dialogues

IRANIAN SHI'ITE AND AMERICAN CHRISTIAN DIALOGUE IN TEHRAN, IRAN
In late October a dialogue planned by FRD and the Peace Lover's Society of Iran was canceled due to political turmoil in Tehran. Eight religious diplomats from the USA were to meet with Muslim clerics and leaders from Iran. This was rescheduled for 2012.

FACING THE CHALLENGES AND OPPORTUNITIES OF GLOBAL, CULTURAL, AND RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY
July 17–20, 22–23, St. Petersburg and Moscow, Russia

FRD's subsidiary, Global Scholarly Publications, co-sponsored two scholarly conferences in Russia to begin to build better relationships with and between scholars and leaders in this nation. From July 17 to 20, the Russian School of Religion and Philosophy in St. Petersburg hosted discussions on Russian views of the relationship between religion and social philosophy in a global world that lacks a common religious or philosophical foundation. Professor Natalia Percherskaya, rector and president of the school, agreed to continue the discussions in more depth by bringing participants to future foundation-sponsored conferences in China and the USA. The foundation's goal is to eventually see Russian Orthodox church leaders begin to engage in genuine interreligious dialogue. It eventually hopes to see the creation of a Russian Orthodox chapter of the foundation whose members will work on building trust between Russia's very diverse traditions, as well as between these religions and the country's secular leaders.

From July 22 to 23, the Global Studies faculty of Moscow State University, the nation's largest university, hosted a scholarly conference at the school to discuss how globalization is challenging relations between Russia, the USA, and China. The program included forthright discussions of current religious, economic, and technological tensions, as well as opportunities that are presenting themselves for making real progress in easing

these tensions and building a more peaceful nation. At the conclusion of the meetings, the Global Studies faculty agreed to come to the United States for the first time to attend FRD's next conference, which will be centered on further exploring how trust (or the lack thereof) affects social, economic, and even religious relations.

INAUGURAL CONFERENCE OF THE LATTER-DAY SAINT CHAPTER OF FRD: DIALOGUE WITH ABRAHAMIC TRADITIONS
June 2010, University of Southern California, Los Angeles, CA

Under sponsorship of the Latter-day Saint (LDS) Chapter of FRD in collaboration with the University of Southern California's Center for Religious Life, some 130 scholars, religious leaders, and laymen involved in interreligious activities convened for a three-day conference titled, *Mormon Engagement with the World Religions: Perspectives and Possibilities with the Abrahamic Traditions.* The LDS Chapter was interested in exploring the theory and practice of interreligious diplomacy and dialogue within the tenets of orthodox LDS Christianity. Most of the discussion therefore aimed at clarifying the warrant for and best practices regarding interreligious action by the Saints. Panels, however, included leaders of the Roman Catholic, Eastern Orthodox, Roman Catholic, Methodist, Evangelical Christian, Conservative Jewish, Reformed Jewish, and Sunni Muslim communities. Each speaker shared their perspectives and experiences with interreligious dialogue, yielding fruitful suggestions and challenges that lie ahead for developing more trustworthy relationships between religions that often see each other as rivals as well as collaborators. The conference was filmed and is posted on the FRD YouTube page. The LDS Chapter has announced its desire to expand dialogue beyond the Abrahamic faith groups soon.

DIALOGUES ON CULTURAL AND RELIGIOUS PLURALISM IN CHINA
March 2010, SUNY Westbury, NY campus

Under sponsorship of FRD's publishing subsidiary, Global Scholarly Publications, seven scholars from the People's Republic of China attended two days of meetings in which they read and heard papers (with simultaneous translation) dealing with the question, "How can China adapt to globalized capitalism without adopting the same cultural values as Western societies?" The conference included discussion of effects of cultural and religious pluralism both between China and western nations and within China itself. The dialogue included a hearty conversation over "What it means to be Chinese in the 21st century." This was the fourth conference Global Scholarly Publications has organized to develop an intercultural dialogue with influential Chinese scholars. Another conference is planned to convene in China in 2011.

DIALOGUE ON THE RELIGIOUS FOUNDATIONS OF MARRIAGE, GENDER, AND SEXUALITY
February 2010, University of Southern California

FRD members were invited to facilitate a private dialogue between eight religious leaders on both sides of a theological contestation over marriage in the context of the California Proposition 8 referendum. Under the sponsorship of the City of Los Angeles Department

for Enhancing Community, FRD facilitated a day-long dialogue at the University of Southern California. The parties met in mixed foursomes at lunch several days prior to the dialogue to become acquainted personally with each other and to decide on the questions they wanted to address in dialogue.

Organization Expansion

FRD Evangelical Chapter**.** On 28 October, the Foundation's Evangelical Chapter sponsored a formal planning meeting to be held in conjunction with the Annual Meeting of the American Academy of Religion in Atlanta, Georgia.

2009

CONFERENCES AND DIALOGUES

For the past eight years the foundation has been developing relationships with religious and ideological leaders especially in areas where religion and ideological conflicts drive political and economic problems. Seeking to find potential intercultural or interreligious diplomats, the foundation has been organizing conferences at educational institutions affiliated with particular worldviews. The following activities were accomplished in 2009:

In Cairo, Egypt

The Foundation participated in a conference on dialogue between Muslims and the West at Al-Azhar University. This was the impetus to a new relationship with a group of conservative Muslims working in Pakistan and Egypt to build a new movement for unity and righteousness among Muslims that does not rely on aggressive attacks on other cultures or religions to maintain group solidarity. A plan for a formal chapter of the Foundation in Cairo is brewing and should proceed soon.

In Beijing, Shanghai, and Hong Kong

In July, the Foundation, in conjunction with the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences and Global Scholarly Publications, co-sponsored dialogue conferences between scholars and opinion leaders from the secular Marxist tradition and from Protestant, Roman Catholic, Sunni, Shi'ite, Buddhist, and Latter-day Saint traditions. The conference, titled "China and Globalization: Economic and Cultural Conflicts and Opportunities," accomplished trust-building as all parties learned more about each other's different ways of founding moral discipline and value. The next set of dialogues with these partners were held in New York City in March 2010.

At the U.N. in New York City

The Foundation co-sponsored with the Iranian U.N. embassy a three-hour discussion with President Ahmadinejad of Iran who addressed questions posed by more than one hundred American delegates, thirty-five of which were students and professors from Utah universities. FRD also co-sponsored a follow-up discussion the next day between four members of the Iranian parliament (each representing non-Muslim religious traditions in Iran) and forty American religious leaders from Protestant, Catholic, Orthodox, Sunni, Shi'ite, Latter-day Saint, and Jewish communities. The candid responses to questions allowed all sides to see how Iranians are wrestling with complex issues of religion and politics among themselves. A chance for a respectful dialogue has been opened with the religious leaders in Iran, and an invitation for FRD delegates to come to Iran for follow-up meetings has been issued. The Foundation plannned to have a dialogue over religion and politics in Iran and America in 2010.

In Tajikistan

After several years of trust-building work, the Foundation's Director of Global Scholarly Publications, Parviz Morewedge, was selected to help oversee the recent election process and consult with scholars and political diplomats regarding respectfully dealing with internal intercultural conflicts.

In the U.S.

In New York City on 24–25 April, the foundation, in conjunction with SUNY Westbury and Global Scholarly Publications, convened another in a series of conferences titled "Globalization: Economic and Cultural Conflicts and Opportunities" with delegates coming from China, Eurasia, Indonesia and the Middle East.

PUBLICATIONS

FRD researched the materials that will provide the platform for FRD training and continued working on the Foundation's manifesto, titled *Fighting about God—Why We Do It and How We Can Do It Better*. FRD explored collecting essays for a book tentatively titled, *Friendly Foes: Trustworthy Opponents in History*. Through its subsidiary, Global Scholarly Publications, FRD continued to publish Shi'ite Muslim and Chinese scholarly journals, the *Journal of Decision Ethics* (jointly with Oxford University), and several new books, including *Rethinking China's Historical Position* by Wei Xioping on Chinese social-economic theory and practice compared to western theories and practices.

2008

FRD-sponsored interreligious discussion with a Sunni delegation from the Middle East

and Pakistan sponsored by the US State Dept visitor's bureau, held in Highland, Utah.

FRD's bi-annual conference on Diplomacy and Globalization, co-sponsored by the LDS Public Affairs Office in New York City. Focus: "China and the Middle East: Coming into the Global Community, Business, Cultural Values, and National Identity," held in the LDS Temple building, New York City.

FRD-sponsored seminar: "Religious Pluralism and the Thought of Joseph Smith," held in the LDS Temple building, New York City.

FRD presentation on "Teaching About Religions and How to Disagree Respectably in Public Schools," at a conference co-sponsored by FRD and the 3 R's Project (a subsidiary of FRD), held at Westminster College, Salt Lake City, Utah.

FRD participation in the Mennonite Central Committee East/West Dialogue with Mamoud Amadinejad, President of Iran, held in New York City.

2007

FRD conference (joint sponsor with Chinese Academy of Social Sciences) "Sino-U.S. Symposium on Globalization and Its Challenges from a Philosophical and Social Science Viewpoint," held in Beijing, China.

FRD participation in the Mennonite Central Committee East/West Dialogue with Mamoud Amadinejad, President of Iran, held in New York City.

FRD attendance at the Emory University conference on Law and Religion, Atlanta, Georgia.

FRD-sponsored Muslim-Latter-day Saint dinner and dialogue held at the main Sunni Mosque in Las Vegas, Nevada. Discussion: "How Mormons and Muslims engage in prayer—similarities and differences."

FRD presentation to the Key Club in Salt Lake City, Utah on the topic, "What Can Be Done to Improve Relations with Muslim countries in the Middle East."

2006

FRD's bi-annual annual conference on Diplomacy and Globalization, co-sponsored with the LDS Public Affairs Office in New York City and the Iranian Cultural Foundation, held in New York City.

Randall Paul, the founder and President, made progress in writing a manifesto of FRD's theory and program with the tentative title, *Why We Fight About God and How We Can Do It Better*.

2005

FRD-sponsored presentation at Culture of Connection Conference and Workshop: "Interreligious Diplomacy, an Example of Dialogue between a Latter-day Saint and Evangelical," participants, FRD President Charles Randall Paul, Ph.D. and Reverend Gregory C.V. Johnson, held in connection with FRD's bi-annual annual conference on Diplomacy and Globalization, co-sponsored with the LDS Public Affairs Office in New York City and the Iranian Cultural Foundation, held in New York City

FRD obtained its final 501(c)3 as a public charitable organization after several years of operation and fundraising approximately $300,000 from several sources.

2004

FRD-sponsored workshop and teacher training: "How to Teach About Critical Differences in Religion Respectfully," Salt Lake City, Utah.

FRD and Utah Valley State College joint-sponsored Community Dialogue on Religious Differences and Problems in Utah County.

FRD and Bard University joint-sponsored bi-annual conference on Diplomacy and Dialogue between Cultures, St. John the Divine, New York City, New York.

FRD private conference with the Iranian ambassador to the UN, Mohammed Zarif, regarding potential dialogue engagement between Shi'ite clerics in Iran and U.S. Southern Baptists.

2003

FRD presentation at the Sunstone Education Foundation's symposium on the theological and ethical foundation for persuasive interreligious contestation, San Francisco, California.

FRD-sponsored conference on "Diplomacy, Conflict Resolution, and Globalization," held at Union Theological Seminary, New York City, New York.

FRD and Harvard Alumni Association "Dialogue on the Religious Divide in Utah," Salt Lake Community College, Salt Lake City, Utah.

FRD presentation: "Theological Foundations for Peace and Conflict," Center for Studies on New Religions (CESNUR) conference, held at Brigham Young University, Provo, Utah.

FRD and Waterford School co-sponsored training workshop: “Dealing with Conflict over Different Worldviews and Religious Practices,” held in Salt Lake City, Utah.

2002

FRD established its subsidiary, Global Scholarly Publications (GSP), to publish books and journals often in bi-lingual format that bring important texts to societies that do not have access to them. This is a diplomatic step for showing respect between people that currently do not have much of it. Dr. Parviz Morewedge joined FRD as the Director of GSP. GSP also arranges global conferences between scholars of different cultures to produce materials for publication. The Middle East, Eurasia, and China is the primary focus of GSP’s diplomatic outreach.

2001

FRD obtained its 501(c)3 preliminary status as a charitable corporation. It now accepts donations that are tax deductible to the donor. Program planning began this year with a focus on improving dialogue between religious communities. A nation-wide advisory trip was taken by Randall Paul to discover the state of scholarship and actual practice in the area of religious diplomacy.

2000

FRD was established in the State of Illinois as a non-profit organization aiming to build trust and friendship between religious critics and rivals, and thus improve chances for peace and cooperation in religiously diverse families, communities and societies. The founder, Randall Paul, began seeking collaborators. Gerald T. Snow and Daniel C. Peterson became the initial board members of FRD. (FRD was first called The Foundation for Interreligious Diplomacy but shortened its name to Foundation for Religious Diplomacy in 2010.)